Translation and Cultural Adaptation Protocol

Fillable PDF. Click a blue box to type; tick the small squares. Save with **File › Save** and attach the saved PDF to your assignment. Works best in the free Adobe Acrobat Reader; macOS Preview and web browsers also work. If an answer does not fit its box, continue it on an extra page. Source: `Step_10_Survey_Distribution/translation_protocol.md` (rebuild with `tools/make_fillable_pdfs.py`).

This protocol ensures that translated survey instruments are linguistically equivalent, culturally appropriate, and scientifically defensible. A poorly adapted instrument can introduce systematic measurement bias that invalidates cross-cultural comparison.

Phase 1 — Forward Translation

1. Hire a **certified professional translator** who is a native speaker of the *target* language and fluent in the source language.
2. Brief the translator on the study topic, the target population's educational level, and any technical jargon that requires a specific rendering (e.g., "ecosystem services," "biodiversity").
3. Provide the translator with a **translation brief**: a list of constructs being measured, any validated scale sources, and notes on item intent.

Phase 2 — Back-Translation

1. Hire a **second, independent translator** (blind to the original instrument) who is a native speaker of the *source* language and fluent in the target language.
2. This translator produces a back-translated version from the target-language draft only.
3. Compare the back-translation to the original source instrument.
4. Flag any items where the back-translation diverges meaningfully in meaning, tone, or implication.

Phase 3 — Expert Committee Review

1. Assemble a small bilingual panel (2–4 people): ideally includes a local researcher, a community partner, and/or a subject-matter expert from the study region.
2. Review flagged items from Phase 2.
3. Resolve discrepancies by consensus, prioritizing the **semantic intent** of the original item over literal translation.
4. Document all changes and rationale in a translation log.

Phase 4 — Cognitive Pre-Testing

1. Recruit **8–15 participants** from the target population (native speakers of the target language, representative of your study sample).
2. Use think-aloud or retrospective probing interviews (see Step 9 cognitive interviewing methods).

3. Record which items cause confusion, hesitation, or laughter.
4. Revise items that consistently cause problems.
5. A second round of cognitive testing may be needed after major revisions.

Phase 5 — Final Review and Sign-Off

1. Have the final translated version proofread by a native speaker not involved in earlier phases.
2. Check formatting (scale labels, response options, instructions) in the survey platform.
3. Pilot the full translated version in the survey platform before launch (see Step 9 pilot study guidance).
4. Archive all translation versions, briefs, and logs for the supplementary materials of your publication.

Machine Translation Notes

Tools like **DeepL** or **Qualtrics' built-in translation** can generate a fast first draft for Phase 1. This is acceptable *only* as a starting point — it must be reviewed by a human professional translator before proceeding to Phase 2. Machine translation frequently fails on:

- Idioms and colloquialisms
- Hedged academic language (e.g., "tends to," "is associated with")
- Culturally loaded terms (e.g., "wilderness," "nature," "native species")
- Gendered grammar (Spanish, French, Portuguese)

Translation Log Template

Item #	Original (EN)	Translated Version	Back-Translation	Discrepancy?	Resolution	Date
Q1						
Q2						